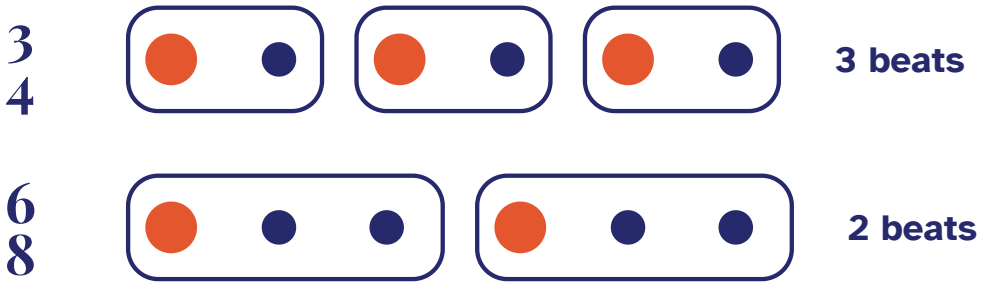
PART II · TIME · 5

# Compound and irregular time

Compound time skips: each dotted beat splits into **three**. Irregular time keeps you guessing, with **five or seven** counts in uneven groups. (9/4, 12/4 and /16 signatures are rare.)

THE SECRET

**Dotted beats split in three: 6/8 is two big beats.**




*Same six quavers, new groups*

SIMPLE OR COMPOUND?

In **simple time** each beat divides into **two**. In **compound time** each beat is a dotted note and divides into **three**.

**Quick test:** a top number of 6, 9 or 12 means compound. Divide it by 3 to find the beats: 6/8 has 2, 9/8 has 3, 12/8 has 4.

## Compound time

| TIME SIGNATURE | EACH BAR HOLDS | FIRST MET |
|---|---|---|
| 6/8 | 2 dotted crotchets | Level 1 |
| 9/8 | 3 dotted crotchets | Level 3 |
| 12/8 | 4 dotted crotchets | Level 3 |
| 6/4 | 2 dotted minims | Level 4 |

## Counting 6/8




Slowly, count all six quavers. At speed, feel two beats, on 1 and 4: “1 & a, 2 & a”.

PART II · TIME · 5 · CONTINUED

## Irregular time

| TIME SIGNATURE | EACH BAR HOLDS | FIRST MET |
|---|---|---|
| 5/4 | 5 crotchets: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3 | Level 5 |
| 7/4 | 7 crotchets: 4 + 3 or 3 + 4 | *Extra* |
| 5/8 | 5 quavers: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3 | *Extra* |
| 7/8 | 7 quavers: 2 + 2 + 3 or 3 + 2 + 2 | *Extra* |

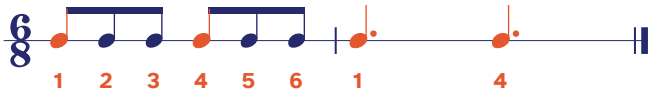
**UNEVEN GROUPS IN 4/4**

Many dances keep 4/4 but group the eight quavers 3 + 3 + 2: “1 2 3, 1 2 3, 1 2”.




**EXAMPLE**

### Count 6/8 in two
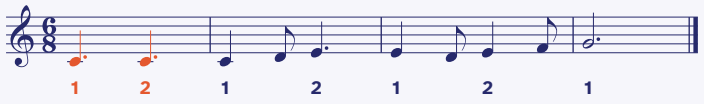



1. **Slowly, count all six:** 1 2 3 4 5 6.
2. **Lean on 1 and 4**, the red notes.
3. **Faster, count only those:** two beats, each a dotted crotchet.

6/8 has **two beats** in a bar, each split into three.

**YOU KNOW THIS**

### Row, Row, Row Your Boat




Two big beats in every bar, each a **dotted crotchet**: “Row, row”. Inside each beat, “gent-ly” splits it into three. That is 6/8.

**Try it.** Sway twice per bar while you sing it.

**THINK OF IT** Like a skipping rope: two big swings, each with three little steps inside.

**SEE ALSO**
Time signatures p. 41 · Rhythm: groups and upbeats p. 45

**PRACTISE IT**
Workbook Levels 1–4 · Compound time · Online: Rhythm clock